

## Is Our Attention for Sale? | James Williams

<https://www.thersa.org/video/shorts/2020/is-our-attention-for-sale>

1. "When information becomes ----- attention becomes a scare -----." Complete the following quote from Herbert Simon:

abundant...resource

2. What goals does technology have for us?

Maximise time on site, clicks, page views, ad views.

3. Which two trends have come together in the current attention economy?

Knowledge of non-rational biases and non-rational dynamics of decision making

System of measurement, message delivery, optimisation, experimentation has developed on the internet.

4. What does this development mean according to the speaker and why it is important?

Industrial scale persuasion is now the primary business model of our first form of global communication. The power has become increasingly centralised amongst certain companies and in certain places.

5. What was the mistake that Aldous Huxley identified?

The infinite appetite for distraction,

## The Battle for Your Time: Exposing the Costs of Social Media | Dino Ambrosi |

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=4TMPXK9tw5U>

1. What proportion of an average American 18-year-old's free time is taken up with screen time?

93%

2. What does the speaker ask the audience to imagine?

Being at the age of 90 and thinking of all the things you haven't done because you were distracted and what impact has high screen time on your life?

3. What are some of the consequences of the use we make of social media sites? Note down the examples the speaker provides? Instagram/Snapchat/Twitter

Training yourself to become chronically distracted, but consequences not limited to cognition. Social Media platforms influence the way we see ourselves and the world. Instagram says worth is defined

by what you look like and what you do on vacation and implicitly says that transient social approval more important than a few people who deeply care about you. Snapchat says quality of relationships is measured by frequency of interaction. Twitter/X says anything worth saying should be reduced to arbitrary number of characters and that the world is black and white and better to be updated than informed.

4. What does the inherent structure of a book compel us to do?

It says the world is complex and compels us to see the world through other people's eyes with context and forces us to focus on one train of thought for an extended period of time, which nurtures our attention.

5. Which 2 things does the speaker suggest social media platforms need to do in order to monetise its users?

Understand which ads are going to influence you by collecting data

Get you to watch as many of those ads as possible?

6. What is their profit linked to?

How long you scroll for.

7. What 2 things does the speaker suggest people need to do in order to get a good deal out of social media platforms?

Ask yourself what value do the services provide?

How much of your time is that value worth?

8. What are some of the benefits of social media that the speaker mentions?

Foster relationships, introduce you to new ideas, spark social movements.

9. What point does he make about Fear of Missing Out (FOMO)

Realise that while by trying to avoid FOMO you missed out on living.

## **Listening 2: Is Social Media Good for You? | Cliff Lampe**

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=po01VINvCcQ>

1. What is the purpose of the talk according to the speaker?

To convince the audience that social media is good for you.

2. What is the common narrative regarding social media? Note some examples.

That it is bad for us. That we're often 'alone together'. That we're replacing our real relationships with inauthentic relationships and we compare ourselves negatively to others and makes us sad.

3. How did people perceive technology in the past in terms of its impact on human being?

People have always been anxiety – jazz would replace thinking/telephone would lead to rude society; Plato said writing would lead to degradation of humanity.

4. What has the speaker been studying for the last ten years?

The relationship between social networking sites and social capital – how networks with others can help us physically, psychologically, financially.

5. What does he say about communication?

That it helps us build relationships.

6. How does social media play a role in developing social capital?

Social media provides weak ties that provide you with different, novel information and resources. Even ephemeral relationships can be beneficial. Anonymity can help us to say things we might not be able to say to close friends. Social media is good for social organisations and raises the voice of the powerless and gives people the chance to become their own media and to become change agents.

7. What is it about social media that allows these relationships to develop?

Each platform has a variety of tools that allows us to curate our own presence and enhances the virality/persistence/edibility of our uploads etc. It enables lightweight social grooming that can be powerful.

8. What 2 things do we need to do to increase our chances of benefiting from social media?

We need to become more literate about social media and not assume that everybody knows how to use it well. We need to teach social media in school.

Change the way we design social media platforms.

Follow up discussion.

In light of what you have listened to today, which speaker do you find most persuasive and does it make you consider changes to your own use of social media?

